

Hollow Veil

RPG Souls-like (Experimental)

Game Design Document

Version 1.0

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Game Overview

Genre: Action RPG / Souls-like

Engine: Unreal Engine 5

Platform: PC (Windows)

Perspective: Third Person

Status: Experimental Prototype

Team Size: Solo Developer

Hollow Veil is an experimental action RPG inspired by the Souls-like genre. It features stamina-based combat, complex dodge mechanics, stealth kill systems, and sword combo montages — all engineered from scratch using Unreal Engine 5 Blueprints. This project served as a deep-dive into advanced combat system design and enemy AI programming.

Combat System

Stamina-Based Combat

- Every action (attacking, dodging, sprinting) consumes stamina
- Stamina regeneration rate varies based on player state (idle vs. guarding)
- Over-exertion leaves the player vulnerable — strategic pacing is key

Sword Combo System

- Multi-hit combo chains using **Animation Montages**
- Light and heavy attack variations with different damage and speed profiles
- Combo windows — timing-based inputs for chaining attacks
- Animation-driven hit detection using **Anim Notify** events

Dodge & Evasion

- Directional dodge rolls with i-frames (invincibility frames)
- Dodge canceling — allows breaking out of attack animations
- Stamina cost per dodge forces strategic use

Stealth Kill Mechanic

- Backstab system for unaware enemies — instant kill with unique animation
- Detection based on enemy awareness cone and noise levels
- Crouch movement reduces detection range

Enemy AI Design

- AI-driven enemies with patrol, chase, attack, and retreat states
 - **Behavior Trees** for state management and decision-making
 - Enemy attack patterns with telegraphed animations for player readability
 - Aggression scaling — enemies become more aggressive at low health
 - Group awareness — nearby enemies can be alerted during combat
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</> Technical Implementation

Unreal Engine 5

Blueprints

Animation Montages

Anim Notify

Behavior Trees

AI Perception

Collision System

IK (Inverse Kinematics)

- Entire combat system built in **Blueprints** — no C++ required
 - Custom **Damage System** with damage types, resistances, and critical hits
 - Animation-driven combat using **Montages** and **Anim Notifies** for hit windows
 - AI enemies using **UE5 AI Perception System** for sight and hearing detection
 - Modular weapon system allowing for future weapon variety
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🎯 Design Goals & Learnings

- Master complex combat system architecture in UE5
- Understand animation-driven gameplay and montage systems
- Implement challenging but fair enemy AI behavior
- Explore stamina management as a core balancing mechanic
- This experimental project informed combat design approaches for future titles

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